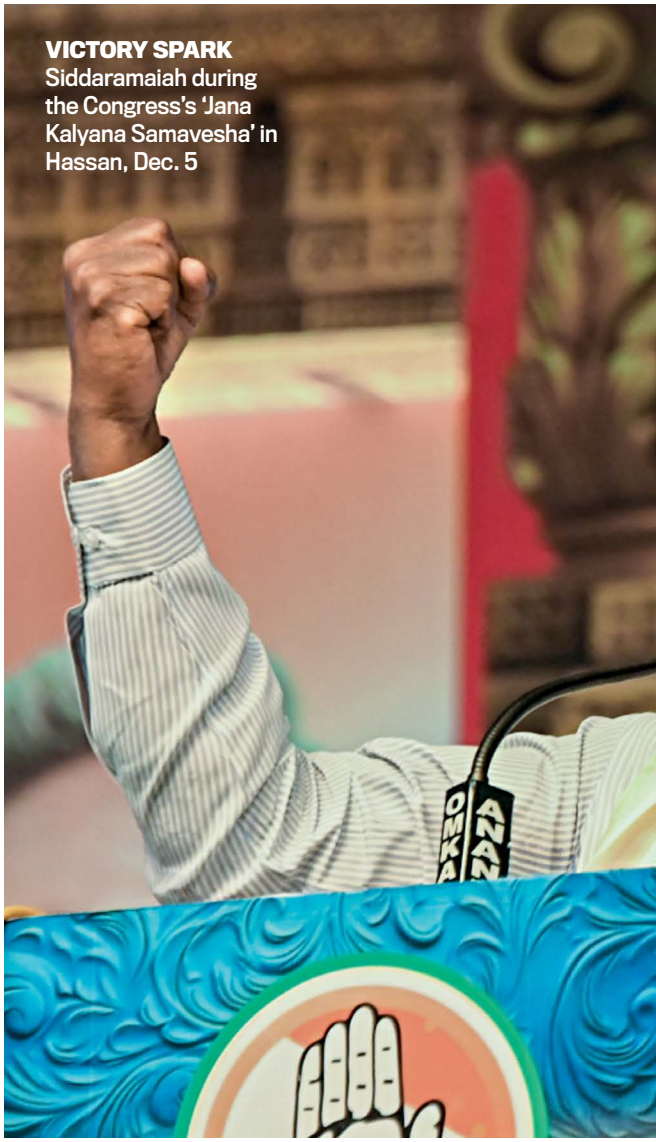
REGAINING MOMENTUM

CHIEF MINISTER SIDDARAMAIAH CAPITALISES ON THE CONGRESS'S BYPOLL SUCCESS TO TACKLE POLITICAL CHALLENGES AND REBUILD PUBLIC TRUST. NOW, HE NEEDS TO EXECUTE HIS AMBITIOUS DEVELOPMENT PLANS

By Ajay Sukumaran



VICTORY SPARK Siddaramaiah during the Congress's 'Jana Kalyana Samavesha' in Hassan, Dec. 5

DECEMBER IS WHEN GOVERNMENT OFFICIALS AND THEIR DEPARTMENTS AT VIDHANA SOUDHA IN BENGALURU pack up for a two-week sojourn in the northern city of Belagavi, 500-odd km away. There, a replica of Karnataka's stately secretariat—the Suvarna Vidhana Soudha—hosts the winter session of the state legislature. On December 6, late into the final Friday evening before this shift of venue, Chief Minister Siddaramaiah was occupied with meetings at his residence in Bengaluru as he prepared to face the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led Opposition in the House. The day before, he flexed his political muscles with a massive rally in Hassan, the stronghold of the Janata Dal (Secular) or JD(S). Essentially, Karnataka's ruling Congress is cashing in on the momentum gained from its clean sweep of the recent assembly bypolls. For Siddaramaiah, this victory couldn't have come at a better time.

In the first six months since he took over as CM in May 2023—for the second time in his career—Siddaramaiah focused on delivering the five 'guarantees', or flagship welfare schemes, that were the Congress' election promises. This demanded a tricky fiscal balancing act given that they cost Rs 52,000 crore per annum. Much of the following six months were spent in gearing up for the Lok Sabha election. But no sooner was it over than the Congress ran into a headwind as a combined BJP-JD(S) Opposition stepped up pressure over the alleged embezzlement of funds from a state-run corporation set up for the welfare of scheduled tribes. Close on its heels came the allegation of irregularities in the allocation of housing plots by the Mysore Urban Development Authority (MUDA); in no time, this became a snowball hurtling straight towards